

NOTES

The Ninth Regular Meeting of the Medford School Committee

Monday, May 2, 2022

Regular Meeting: 6:00 PM

To be held at the Howard Alden Memorial Chambers, Medford City Hall.

Join Zoom Meeting

<https://mps02155-org.zoom.us/j/91728927112>

Roll Call for Attendance of Members and the Student Representatives:

Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: all present, zero absent
No student representatives on the call.

Salute the Flag

Good of the Order

Consent Agenda

- Bills and Payrolls
- Regular School Committee Meeting Minutes, 4.11.2022
- Special School Committee Meeting Minutes, 4.25.2022
- Approval of two donations to McGlynn Middle School; \$1500 from Arkanum, Inc. and \$500 from Rasha Arida.

Motion to sever donation approval: Paul Ruseau/Melanie McLaughlin

Motion to approve minutes and bills: Melanie McLaughlin/Kathy Kreatz
Approved 7/0

Motion to approve donations: Melanie McLaughlin/Kathy Kreatz

Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7/0 donations approved.

Report of Subcommittees

- **Communication and Family Engagement Subcommittee Meeting Minutes, 4.27.2022**

Melanie McLaughlin: Did we need to schedule another meeting?

Jenny Graham: When you send those letters back to us, we will schedule another meeting

Motion to approve: Paul Ruseau; seconded by Melanie McLaughlin

Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7/0 minutes approved

- **Rules and Policy Subcommittee Meeting Minutes, 4.27.2022**

Motion to approve: Melanie McLaughlin/Jenny Graham

Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7/0 minutes approved

Report of the Superintendent

1. Superintendent's Updates and Comments - Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Superintendent

I would like to extend our thanks to Tufts University who presented Community grants to both CCSR and the Medford Family Network. Each group received \$2,000. CCSR will utilize the funds for materials for a cleanup of the Middlesex Fells Reservation and the Medford Family Network intends to use its funding for new programs for children with autism, including adaptive swim, soccer lessons and nature hikes.

Thank you to all who came to our MHS campus this weekend to do cleanup. We appreciate all the hard work.

Tonight, our Muslim families and friends are celebrating the end of Ramadan with Eid Al Fitr or Breaking the Fast. Fasting in the month of Ramadan is considered one of the five pillars of Islam. Muslims believe that past year's sins are forgiven, good deeds are multiplied and prayers answered. Eid Mubarak! May Allah flood your lives with happiness, your heart with love, your soul with spirituality, your mind with wisdom!

This is Teacher Appreciation Week and the theme this year is "Teaching is a work of heart". The administrators and families of Medford appreciate the dedication of our teachers. I hope the teachers and staff enjoy the many treats the PTOs have organized for them this upcoming week. The president of the Medford Teachers Union will be speaking tonight and I appreciate all the hard work our teachers and staff are doing.

And next week is Nurses Appreciation week. A million thank yous to the unbelievable Medford Nursing staff who have provided us so much support over the pandemic. They have gone above and beyond to keep our students and staff safe and healthy.

And, I want to extend my thanks to the Administrative Professionals and Principals who also had their days of appreciation in the last week.

This weekend, our robotics students with guidance from teacher Sam Christy participated in the New England Robotics Championship and WON! They are now eligible to compete in the National Championship in Long Beach, CA, later this month! Simply fabulous!

Also, this weekend, the Medford High School Orchestra and Marching Band competed in the Music in the Parks competition. The Orchestra came in first with an overall rating of Excellent and the Marching Band came in first with an overall rating of Superior. This is a great accomplishment! Congratulations to our musical Mustangs!

Lastly, we extend our congratulations to senior Connor Finnegan, who scored (10) goals as a member of the Boys Lacrosse Team. This is the most goals ever scored by one lacrosse player in Mustang history, as the Mustangs beat Malden, 19-0. The Mustangs are 9-2 and just became the GBL Champs!

I am happy to see that our community is bustling and hosting more and more in-person events including concerts, plays and awards ceremonies over the course of the next few weeks. In particular, during the week of May 9th - 13th, we will be hosting open houses for incoming kindergarteners and middle schoolers:

Tuesday, May 10th - McGlynn Middle School Open House for Incoming 6th Graders & their Families - 6-8 PM & the Andrews Middle School Open House is Thursday, May 12th - 6-8 PM

Wednesday, May 11th - Kindergarten Open Houses - 2 PM

Lastly, I would like to remind you all that this Sunday, May 8th is Mother's Day. I would like to wish all the mothers and grandmothers in the MPS community a Very Happy Mother's Day!

2. Report on Unified Sports and Adaptive Physical Education - Joan Bowen, Director of Pupil Services, Rachel Perry Director of Physical Education & Health Education and Carla Andre, Adaptive Physical Education Teacher

[Link to presentation](#)

Melanie McLaughlin: Thank you so much Carla and Rachel. So nice to see this come to fruition. Were there students interested in unified that you had to turn away?

Carla Andre: We took all 16 who were interested. I would consider two teams in the future. In the middle school, we took 30 kids because of the size of gym and staff but we did have to have a waitlist. John Skerry and Nicole Sylvester, David Richard, Denise DesJardin, Cyndi Griffin and Michael McLaughlin have helped. We are always looking for volunteers.

Melanie McLaughlin: I appreciate the thoughtfulness of how you put it together. You started a trend in the community. There is now an adaptive theater program.

Jenny Graham: I recall in last year's budget, we added staff to support the Adaptive program.

Rachel Perry: .5 fte and that is Carla's position.

Jenny Graham: Do you anticipate needing more staff?

Rachel Perry: Not in the next couple of years.

Melanie McLaughlin: You mentioned that purchases for Adaptive PE came out of the PE budget. Is there additional need?

Rachel Perry: At this point, we don't need anything else.

Carla Andre: Hopefully we can use the MVTHS and make some low tech equipment to move the program forward.

Supt. Edouard-Vincent: Thank you. I enjoyed being able to attend the basketball games. It was great seeing the students working together and cheering for each other. It brought many families together in our community in a different way.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: When is the last track and field meet?

Carla Andre: This Thursday in Swampscott.

3. Recommendation to approve Medford as a No School Choice District - Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Superintendent

Every year, we have to take a vote and send it to DESE. I am asking for your support to keep Medford as a no school choice district. My recommendation is to remain no school choice district.

Melanie: Could we get a brief explanation of what that is?

Supt. Edouard-Vincent: If you are a school choice district you can send and receive students from other districts. I feel that we have our hands full servicing the population we have.

Paul Ruseau: Motion to approve/seconded by Melanie McLaughlin

Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7/0 motion approved to maintain Medford as a No school choice district

4. Report on McGlynn Playground Inspections - Dr. Peter J. Cushing, Assistant Superintendent of Secondary Education

[Link to report:](#)

Peter Cushing: Over the past several months, the DPW has cleared standing water at least twice and the new DPW director is coming up with a plan to replace the french drain in the back of the playground. The area has been marked by Dig Safe. The gas company has not responded to mark the playground area so we are waiting for that before it can be replaced.

There is a steering committee. We have three pre approved vendors who have submitted bids. Copley Wolfe Design Group was chosen for their emphasis on making it universally accessible.

The CPSI inspector says that the playground is not very engaging or support much play. It is the city's largest playground for schools. Both playground structures are for ages 5-12 despite having no age signage.

The design study is moving forward. We have most of the board identified. We have two spots open awaiting further outreach to reach all voices in Medford. We will invite public input as well as for students to be involved in designing the playground. It is a regional destination playground not just the schools. We have met with the city administration to try to secure additional funding. Danehy Playground is an example of an universally accessible playground.

Jenny Graham motioned for a playground inspection (up to \$2000). We had it inspected in early March. It cost \$900 (Playground Inspectors of NE). Given the perceived deterioration of the poured in place soft surface that needs to be replaced, she suggested a head drop test which costs \$2100. It passed at all heights tested. There are certain times that people have claimed that the playground had caused injuries. We looked at the nursing reports and it doesn't seem to be true. Most were attributable to typical childhood play.

There were five specific areas identified in the report. Two were given high hazard concern and the school is working to mitigate them: a hole in the structure that is higher than it should be and a falling height that is too high.

There are teachers, ots and pts on the committee.

Showed images of standing water in the playground, unplowed portions of fields, rusty walkways and bridges, deterioration of the poured in surface, spiral slide underwater and various elements of concern.

In the report itself, the inspector said that the playground is at the end of its usable life. The maintenance of the structure has not been done to keep it up to date.

We will be notifying the committee at the end of this week.

5. Labor Relations Update - David Murphy, Assistant Superintendent of Finance and Operations

Slides on screen.

Paul Ruseau: If the audience can't be polite, he can't present.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: Signs are fine but please be quiet so Mr. Murphy can be heard.

Dave Murphy: MPS Labor Relations Update and FY 23 Budget Planning
[Link to presentation:](#)

MPS has ten collective bargaining units representing the vast majority of our employees. It is normal in the course of collective bargaining, that there will be points of disagreement. I have a responsibility to make it clear that the ten CBAs represent hundreds of public servants that the MPS benefit from on a daily basis. Regardless of other final details we might disagree on - they are the ones that do the work. There is no question that the people doing the work, helping the children to lead more fulfilling lives are with us this evening.

Cafeteria workers agreement not yet open. Negotiating the other 9.

Specifics of the proposal need to remain confidential. Items taken out of context don't make sense. There are overarching objectives that transcend each of our negotiating:

- Quality of instructional time
- Efficiency/use of time
- Increase wages to maintain competitiveness while ensuring sustainability
- Look for shared interests

It is necessary for us to maintain flexibility to adapt to unforeseen circumstances and not create deficits.

There is a budgeted amount of a budgeted 2% cost of living increase. For FY 22 and 23, our fixed cost increases are the increases in next year's fiscal budget where decisions have already been made (steps and lanes).

Melanie McLaughlin: Can you explain steps and lanes to those who are watching?

Dave Murphy: In the wage tables, step increases represented by rows increases based on years of experience; lanes are based on pd credits. Steps have greater budgetary impact than lanes.

Other fixed cost increases include energy and utilities. We are in the third year of our contract with Eastern Bus with a \$50k increase. Special Education - out of district tuition and transportation costs estimated to be \$750K increase.

Paul Ruseau: You are talking increases. Not a \$50K cost - it is \$50K increase.

Dave Murphy: Correct

Fixed cost liabilities between 2.4m to 2.6 million dollars.

That amount represents a serious challenge to the district. In order for us to recruit talent, we do have to have sustainable wage increases. If there is instability in the system, it will lead to significant layoffs and it becomes even more challenging to do the work for students.

MA is seeing a projected increase in Ch. 70 funding. This year is 1.6 million dollars but we are largely a local contribution district. It represents only a fraction of our budget. Medford is already over by a significant net spending number that the state requires.

Melanie McLaughlin: What is chapter 70?

Dave Murphy: Ch. 70 is the amount of money we get from Beacon Hill (state revenues). Local contribution number is the minimum that the city must provide to keep the schools going. The breakdown of the ratio of these numbers is designed to be repr of the socio economic demographics of the community and the needs of the students. Provides a floor not a ceiling.

2.5 million dollar fixed cost increase does not include the 2% cost of living increase.

We are anticipating external funding. We have used ESSER funding to host acceleration programs, Camp Mustang, engagement team, transportation improvements for high school students. We cannot use the ESSER funding for any purpose. It is a temporary source of funding and has no signs of being renewed. Our responsibility is to look for efficiencies.

We will continue to negotiate in good faith with regards to our partners. I understand the frustration and we will do our best to meet our responsibilities.

Jenny Graham: The 2% COLA equates to what?

Dave Murphy: For FY 22 \$1,000,000 representing all ten bargaining units. Does not include non unit employees. Compounding impact in every year going forward. The budget for a school system is almost all personnel costs and salaries. The strategic priority is to make sure we have the staff in place to serve at this moment.

Jenny Graham: The last two years have been budget anomalies. Last year, we got a 8.2 % increase. In the early days, we got zero. What is our history? What is a typical increase in the local contribution?

Dave Murphy: The average personnel increase percentage is 4% including COLAs and Steps and Lanes. The local contribution corresponds to those numbers.

Jenny Graham: That 4% would include additional positions being added?

Dave Murphy: Yes.

Jenny Graham: How many positions did we add from last fiscal year? There were positions added (in the 15 -20 range, majority being grant funded).

Paul Ruseau: We had plenty of years where we didn't increase. I am happy that since 2013 we have been giving increases.

Presentations of the Public (not to begin before 7:00 pm)

- **Presentation by Medford Teachers Association regarding ongoing contract negotiations- Ms. Charlene Douglas, President.**
[Link to Remarks:](#)

Melanie McLaughlin: Thanks for the presentation and slide deck.

Kathy Kreatz; Thank you for the presentation and happy teachers appreciation week.

Supt. Edouard-Vincent: Thank you for the slide deck. There will be a session tomorrow and thank you to the teachers who worked on the packet.

Jenny Graham: Are you telling us you are at an impasse on these issues?

Charlene Douglas: We feel very strong about the issues and we will continue to come to the table. We have made many conciliations already. We are close on a lot of things but we want a decent raise. 2% is not going to work for us.

Jenny Graham: We can't respond to any of the issues you made because it has to be done at the bargaining table.

Charlene Douglas: We have respect for the negotiation process and I believe Mr. Murphy made reference to that tonight. We know there are other districts with sizable increases. Arlington gave \$500 to those who got booster shots.

Jenny Graham; We appreciate our teachers very much.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: Happy teachers appreciation week. I hope we can come to an agreement on this.

Steven South, 106 Damon Road: Secretary/Treasurer of Teamsters 25: Central Admin is proposing 1-2% COLA increases yet we are experiencing the highest rates of inflation in 40-50 years. No unit is going to settle for 2%. It is not feasible.

Paul Ruseau: Motion to make all rules and engagements of negotiation public. One side of the bargaining blasts the content and at times misrepresents the content of the negotiations all over facebook while the administration is not allowed to comment.

David Murphy: The ground rules for all proposals are documents between the parties. For each bargaining unit, I would want to confer with each party individually. Identifying a specific proposal in a vacuum without context is dangerous. We are continuing to abide by the confidentiality that we believe to lead to a more constructive negotiation. My recommendation to the committee is to get back tot bargaining table and continue to negotiate.

Paul Ruseau: I don't know what the point of the rules are when one half abides by them and you don't get to say whatever you want and we cannot even respond to the emails. I will withdraw this as the motion as I put it doesn't work for all parties. Let the bargaining team do their work.

Hannah O'Brien: Resigned as a paraprofessional. \$51 dollars a day to come to work for our most vulnerable students. Schools are going to bear the brunt of the mental health epidemic. You continue to

push testing when they are not at grade level. Do you want to continue to lose people who care? I hope you make the decision to support the teachers.

Max Heinegg: MHS Teacher and resident. Spoke on behalf of the teachers.

Andy Milne: Quincy Street, Medford. 31 rewarding years as a teacher. Being nice and being appreciative are two things that you can do for free. These people have been up since 7:00. 44% of Massachusetts teachers have stated they plan to leave teaching in the next two years. Do you realize how many teachers we are losing? There is one department that is not here because they are leaving. They have been bullied. They have been overworked. How many of you have set down with teachers regarding the existential crisis of having their prep time away. Do you know how demoralizing it is for teachers to be asked to cover a class you have no expertise in? How are we going to replace these people? The number one needs are the children's needs. You will be in a crisis where you will have no teachers, especially one department that is MCAS tested. Last year was my hardest year teaching. What was the first meeting this year? About starting the evaluation process. We have a lot to be proud of. We are Medford. My last statement is - this is not the time to bottom dollar it. People are leaving for whiter, suburban suburbs or for other professions. See how many have left for Newton North. It is not always about money. It is also about appreciation. Value the primary relationship of our town - students and teachers.

Sean Beagan - 362 Lawrence Road Medford - my interest in strictly child related and child focused. I know that kids in this city have had a horrendous two years and it is not the teachers fault. I hope this is not the next anxiety for these kids. I have heard hyperbole and grandstanding tonight and I have heard about specific negotiations you can't respond to. I hope the two sides can get together very quickly and come to a decision. We have had some great experiences in the MPS. Keep the kids in mind as well. Let's get this wrapped up very quickly.

Melanie McLaughlin: Thanks to those who came up to the podium. Thank you for the invitation to visit. We can't just show up in teachers' classrooms.

New Business

2022-28 Offered by Paul Ruseau

Policy BEDH - POLICY ON PUBLIC COMMENT AND PRESENTATIONS OF THE PUBLIC has a numbering error in section III - Presentations of the Public. Therefore the lettering will be corrected as follows:

Section III number 1 - Purpose will be renumbered "A".

Section III number 2 - Submitting a presentation will be renumbered "B".

Section III, D - Authority Determination will be renumbered "C".

Section III, E - Appealing an authority determination will be renumbered "D".

Meeting Date Requested: 5/2/2022

Submitted Date: 4/14/2022

Motion to suspend second reading.

Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Motion to suspend second reading. 7/0

Motion to approve:

Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn. 7/0 motion passes.

Reports Requested

2022-27 - Update on Implementation of NWEA MAP offered by members Sharon Hays, Melanie McLaughlin and Mea Mustone from our March 21, 2022 meeting.

Condolences

The Medford School Committee expresses its sincere condolences to the family of Doris Luppi, a fifth grade teacher at the former Forest Park School.

The Medford School Committee expresses its sincere condolences to the family of Anthony Pasquale, a member of the Mustang Hall of Fame and a Captain of the 1978 Mustang Football Team, the only MHS football team who won a Super Bowl Title.

The Medford School Committee expresses its sincere condolences to the family of Michael Francis Falco, husband of Debora Falco, a paraprofessional at the McGlynn Elementary School

The Medford School Committee expresses its sincere condolences to the family of Kevin Hickey, Sr., a long time Vocational teacher and class advisor.

The Medford School Committee expresses its sincere condolences to the family of Stephen J. Day, who taught history at Medford High School for 35 years.

Next Meeting

Budget hearings will be announced in the next day or two.

- Monday, May 16, 2022, 6:00PM: Regular School Committee Meeting - Alden Memorial Chambers, Medford City Hall in addition to zoom:
<https://mps02155-org.zoom.us/j/99123771506>

Adjournment

Motion to adjourn: Paul Ruseau/Melanie McLaughlin

Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn

7/0 meeting adjourned.